



The ELX desktop has icons similar to those of Microsoft Windows

except direct package selection, which is tedious. Lycoris Desktop/LX installed the entire set of packages on the hard drive.

RHEL lets you choose between Personal Desktop, Workstation, Server and Custom. The different options have different combinations of packages, and you can further modify this package list.

Though the default boot loader for most was Grub, you can also opt for the older LILO boot loader. Mandrake still depends only on LILO. In a dual-boot scenario, you can select

which OS it boots into as default. Xandros was the only one to recognise another existing Linux installation and add it to the boot menu.

Installation

For all the distributions, the install time is less than half an hour—the only difference is with the number of CDs you have to change. For example, SuSE has 5, Mandrake and Red Hat have 4, while Xandros, Lycoris and ELX have just one each.

One excellent aspect of Lycoris Linux is that you can configure various settings such as networking, printers, VGA, etc., while the packages are still installing. The bottom of the screen shows the install status, and you can spend time configuring the different components. If you're done with the configuration before the installation process ends, you can play *Solitaire* to pass the time. Thus, installation isn't a bore, and you save the time you normally spend, after an install, configuring your devices.

Most distributions did well when setting up the display, network, printer, keyboard, mouse, etc., but Xandros and Lycoris caused a few problems on our test machine.

Security

Only Lycoris demands the creation of an additional user account during installation, for better security. Red Hat and SuSE warn you not to use root as the daily account. Mandrake goes as far as providing a 'No Password' button for the root, allowing a blank password, a highly undesirable feature.

While entering the root password, SuSE offers a choice of 'DES', 'MD5' and 'Blowfish' encryption, and also warns you if you try to use the username as a part of the password. ELX and Red Hat do not provide too many options, but allow you to use MD5 encryption and shadow passwords.

Mandrake offers four security levels for the firewall, but in a lapse of security, leaves the firewall off by default—bad news for Linux novices. ELX BizDesktop does better, by setting the default firewall setting to 'Medium'.

Xandros gives you total security over data communication by assigning users permissions to use dial-up connections, both modem-based and LAN-based.

The popularity of Windows, is also its downfall—the majority of viruses circulating the globe affect only the Windows OS family. You could even start a virus collection on your Linux box, and never worry about your computer crashing. Usually, Linux does not scan incoming mails for viruses, or block attachments. This, however, will have no adverse effect on Linux. You can set up anti-virus software on your Linux machine, to



1/2 page V AD